

Night Signal

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Chapter 1

Segment 1

The relay station had been silent for eleven years until the lamp flickered at 03:14. Mara watched the amber pulse reflect in the observation glass and felt, for the first time since the evacuation, that someone else might still be listening. She did not call the council. She did not wake the crew. She opened the channel and said hello into the dark, and the dark answered with a voice that knew her name. It was not a friendly voice. It was not hostile either. It sounded like distance itself, compressed into syllables. Mara wrote the time in her log and kept the line open until dawn, when the signal dissolved into static as if it had never been more than a dream. But the lamp stayed warm, and that was enough to change the schedule for every watch that followed.
